capitalist groups, providing the local bourgeoisie with the means they lack to have a relatively more favourable status within the development process associated and integrated with imperialism. The formation of these 'national capitalist trusts' on the basis of the agglomeration of state and private capital was the deciding factor for the expansionist impetus that transformed Brazil into an exporter of manufactured goods and capital. In this way, the state was the basic means for these same conglomerations achieving a scale of production, just as it was the source for elaborating the national sub-imperialist project (the Brazilian Superior War College, the Foreign Ministry, etc.) and the guardian of unity among different bourgeois fractions.

A set of forms of the capital reproduction pattern

Next, as we shall see, due to the level of the capital reproduction pattern, 'the axis of the sub-imperialist structure is organised around the market problem' (Marini 2012:256). At the intermediate level of abstraction, the reproduction pattern is the synthesis of two interlocked determinations, which are: the dialectic between the world economy and dependent capitalism, which determines social formations; and the dialectic between the social-economic formations and the real motion controlling dependent capitalism in various historical conjunctures. Thus, the 'external' is internalised and the 'internal' is externalised. In this regard, the investigation of sub-imperialism as a set of forms of the reproduction pattern[8] takes the history of the succession of different patterns into account, having as its analytical benchmark the forms capital has assumed (cyclical regularities and changes considered from the point of view of the use-value produced and of the value process itself) in a socio-economic formation in which both economic and political conditions had matured, transforming it into a sub-imperialist country.

Just as in imperialism where the expansion of capitalist power and of imperialist states exercises the effect of countervailing the law of the tendency for the rate of profit to fall and other contradictions that emanate from the logic of value and class struggle, in sub-imperialism the contradictions inherent in dependent capitalism are displaced. Hence, under the angle of the reproduction pattern, sub-imperialism is located in the juxtaposition of the laws of the dependent economy and the international division of labour governing every period of the world economy. In Marini's words, sub-imperialism originates in and is defined by

> (a) the restructuring of the world capitalist system that derives from the new international division of labour; (b) the very laws of the dependent economy, essentially: the super-exploitation of labour; the disjuncture